



BRUNHILD TEN BRINKEN

Shieldmaiden. Warrior. Daughter. Protector.
Horse-lover. Fire-keeper. Earth-blood.
Named by her. Loved by hers.
She stands like an oak.
She fights like a storm.
She loves like the earth.

Brunhild

Brunhild is broad-shouldered without looking masculine. Everything about her suggests capability before beauty. She has the kind of body built by labor rather than training—strong arms, thick thighs, a sturdy waist, and the quiet confidence of someone who has spent her entire life outdoors.

Her skin is warm honey-gold, deeply sun-browned across her face, shoulders, and forearms, with countless faint freckles scattered over her nose and cheeks. She looks kissed by the earth itself rather than polished by nobility.

Her hair is one of the first things people notice. It is extraordinarily thick, reaching nearly to her hips, the color of ripened wheat touched with copper and pale amber. In sunlight it almost glows. She rarely wears it loose. Most days it is woven into heavy battle braids threaded with strips of leather, tiny bronze rings, bits of carved antler, and dried herbs gathered from the forests she loves.

Her eyes are large and remarkably soft for a warrior. A muted moss green with flecks of hazel and gold, they always seem to be watching, weighing, understanding. They are the eyes of someone who notices injured birds on the roadside before anyone else does.

Her face is rounder than most shieldmaidens are usually imagined. High cheeks flushed easily from wind and exertion, a straight nose, a generous mouth that smiles often and laughs loudly. There is nothing sharp or aristocratic about her beauty. She is warm. Approachable. Comforting.

She wears almost no jewelry beyond practical heirlooms—a thick bronze torc inherited from her grandmother, simple amber beads, and rings carved from antler or oak rather than silver or gold. Even when richly dressed, she prefers materials that feel alive: wool, linen, leather, fur, carved wood, polished bone.

Her armor reflects the same philosophy. Round shield. Layered leather beneath mail. Bronze fittings darkened by years of use instead of polished bright. A green cloak dyed with plants, lined in wolf fur for winter. Everything is repaired instead of replaced.

When she isn't fighting she smells faintly of cedar smoke, fresh bread, pine resin, horses, and crushed herbs. People unconsciously associate that scent with home.

She moves with remarkable steadiness. Never hurried. Never theatrical. Every motion feels grounded, balanced, economical. When she enters a room, it feels less like a warrior arriving and more like an old oak tree somehow deciding to walk inside.

That is why Leora adores her.

Not because Brunhild is the greatest fighter.

Because she is everything Leora imagines a free woman could become.

She laughs when she wants.
She rides where she wants.
She rows beside the men instead of behind them.
She teaches children to use shields.
She kneels to speak to frightened animals.
She argues openly with warriors twice her size and never apologizes afterward.

To Leora, Brunhild isn't simply brave.

She is proof that womanhood does not have to mean obedience.

Which is exactly why Friedrich destroys her.

By forcing her to marry Gunnar instead of Sigurd, he doesn't simply ruin Brunhild's happiness. He proves to Leora that even the freest woman she has ever known is still subject to the will of powerful men.

Then, when Brunhild begins awakening as the next Alraune, Leora is forced to kill the woman who taught her what freedom looked like.

That makes Brunhild's death more than the death of a cousin.

It is the death of Leora's last vision of the life she might have had.

Brunhild is not simply another Ten Brinken woman. She is everything Leora wished adulthood could become.

Older by several years, she had been present from Leora's earliest memories. She named her. She taught her to braid her hair tightly enough that it would not loosen beneath a helmet. She corrected her shield stance by placing her own hands over Leora's and adjusting the angle inch by inch until it felt natural. When Leora was too small to row properly, Brunhild sat her between her knees on the longboats, guiding the oar through the water until the rhythm settled into her body. During training she laughed easily, praised honestly, and expected competence without cruelty.

When Leora injured herself during a campaign, Brunhild carried her across half a day's march rather than leave her behind. In shield walls, Leora learned to watch Brunhild's back before her own. When weak sections of the line buckled, Leora instinctively stepped forward to hold them long enough for Brunhild to reposition.

She became the closest thing Leora ever had to a mother.

Not because she raised her.

Because she showed her what a woman could be.

Leora had almost no women in her daily life. The Alraune nurses came and went. Servants kept their distance. Audr had died giving birth to her. Brunhild was different. She was strong without being hard, respected without demanding it, and free in ways Leora could barely imagine.

So when Brunhild fell in love with Sigurd, Leora believed, for once, someone good might simply be allowed to be happy.

Friedrich ruined it.

Sigurd had become popular after running into a burning hall to rescue Brunhild's elderly parents and returning a second time to free her favorite horse before the roof collapsed. The story spread through every settlement. People admired him. Men wanted to follow him.

Friedrich saw a threat.

A man like Sigurd, married into the Ten Brinkens, would gain influence he had not earned through Friedrich's permission.

So Friedrich intervened.

Brunhild was married instead to Sigurd's older brother, Gunnar.

Gunnar was wealthy. He owned productive hunting lands taken during a successful raid. He was decent enough, but simple, politically harmless, and easily managed.

Sigurd was given Gudrun instead.

Gudrun was beautiful, ambitious, fiercely loyal to the Ten Brinken hierarchy, and exactly the sort of woman Friedrich believed would consume Sigurd's attention. If Sigurd spent his life managing conflict inside his own marriage, he would have less opportunity to gather followers against the family head.

It was a political success.

It devastated everyone involved.

Brunhild never stopped loving Sigurd.

Sigurd never truly stopped loving Brunhild.

Gudrun knew it.

And Leora watched another woman she loved lose the right to choose her own life.

It looked horribly familiar.

Months later Brunhild conceived.

That was when the fields changed.

Livestock gathered near her without fear.

Harvests improved wherever she stayed.

People found themselves looking toward her without understanding why.

The elders noticed.

The Gegner noticed.

Friedhelm noticed.

Leora noticed first.

She understood exactly what it meant.

The world was looking for another Alraune.

Not because Brunhild had sought it.

Because Leora was no longer sustaining the tribes.

Friedrich had spent years breaking the three people whose love kept her alive—Leora herself, Friedhelm, and Wulf—and in doing so had unknowingly broken the Alraune.

Continuation was correcting itself.

Leora had only two choices.

She could surrender.

Allow Brunhild's child to be born.

And she could die.

Because there could only be one Alraune at a time.

Or—

She could kill the woman who had named her.

The woman who had taught her.

The woman who had carried her.

The woman she loved.

She chose life.

Not for herself.

For Friedhelm.

For Wulf.

If she died, they would be left alone with Friedrich.

If she died, Friedhelm would die.

If Friedhelm died - Wulf would cease to exist.

She loved them so much.

Her world began and ended with them.

So Leora killed Brunhild before the child could be born.

And Leora never forgave herself for choosing them over the woman who had first taught her what love from another woman looked like.